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Pre-travel checklist

Version: 1.1.0 · **Last editorial update:** 22 October 2026

Maintainer: John Quinn, MD, MPH, PhD, EMT-P. Educational draft; see the repository review status.

Start ideally 4-8 weeks before departure (CDC: at least 4-6 weeks; WHO: 4-8 weeks). A visit is still worthwhile if you are travelling sooner.

Risk assessment

[ ] Destination(s), route, and stopovers listed

[ ] Trip type and activities noted (urban, rural, trekking, diving, altitude, etc.)

[ ] Duration and accommodation type noted

[ ] Personal risk factors reviewed (chronic conditions, pregnancy, immune status, age)

[ ] Destination health advisories checked (CDC destination pages, WHO, ECDC, national travel advice)

Vaccines and prevention

[ ] Routine vaccines up to date

[ ] Destination-specific vaccines and boosters discussed with a clinician or travel clinic

[ ] Tick-borne encephalitis vaccination considered if relevant to the destination

[ ] Malaria risk and prevention plan checked, if relevant

[ ] Insect-bite avoidance planned (repellent with DEET or picaridin, protective clothing, screens or nets)

[ ] Food and water safety plan

Medication and supplies

[ ] Regular medicines packed in original containers, with enough for the trip plus possible delays

[ ] Prescription copies, with generic drug names

[ ] Signed doctor's letter for psychotropic or other restricted medicines

[ ] Needles and syringes with a prescription copy, if self-injecting

[ ] Destination rules on importing and carrying medicines checked

[ ] Medicines taken from home rather than bought abroad (counterfeit medicines are common in some countries)

[ ] Basic first-aid kit (dressings, analgesia, oral rehydration, antiseptic, thermometer)

[ ] Broad-spectrum sunscreen with **SPF 30 or higher** and adequate UVA protection (at least 4-star UVA protection, or the UVA-in-a-circle marking), plus protective clothing and shade

[ ] Plan to apply sunscreen generously, reapply at least every 2 hours and immediately after swimming, sweating or towel drying; follow the product instructions

[ ] Hand sanitiser (at least 60% alcohol)

[ ] Condition-specific items if relevant: altitude medicine, asthma inhaler, epinephrine auto-injector for severe allergy

Insurance and access to care

[ ] Travel health insurance covers activities, medical evacuation and repatriation

[ ] Pre-existing conditions declared to the insurer

[ ] Insurance policy number and 24-hour assistance phone number saved offline

[ ] Local emergency number(s) for each destination saved

[ ] List of hospitals or clinics at the destination saved

Documents

[ ] Passport validity and visas checked

[ ] Vaccination records packed, including the International Certificate of Vaccination (ICVP, "Yellow Card") and proof of yellow fever vaccination where required

[ ] Medical summary (diagnoses, regular medicines by generic name, allergies) stored offline

[ ] Emergency contacts shared with someone at home

General good practice (not taken directly from the sources above)

[ ] Health card such as EHIC/GHIC packed, where applicable to your nationality and destination

Sun-protection source

NHS: Sunscreen and sun safety - page reviewed 24 March 2026; checked for this editorial update on 22 October 2026. The SPF/UVA wording above follows this source.

Editable source: checklists/01-pre-travel.md

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In transit and at destination

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In transit

[ ] Move and stretch regularly on long journeys; stay hydrated

[ ] Keep essential medicines in carry-on baggage

[ ] Plan for time-zone changes if medicines are time-critical

[ ] Be aware that jet lag and sleep loss can trigger seizures in people with epilepsy and provoke migraines

Food and water

[ ] Use safe drinking water (bottled, boiled or treated)

[ ] Choose freshly cooked, hot food where hygiene is uncertain

[ ] Wash hands before eating, or use sanitiser (at least 60% alcohol)

[ ] Know how to use oral rehydration for diarrhoea

Environment and activity

[ ] Heat, cold and altitude precautions followed

[ ] Sun protection and hydration maintained

[ ] Insect-bite avoidance continued (repellent, protective clothing, screens or nets)

[ ] Tick checks after outdoor activity in tick areas

When to seek care promptly

[ ] Fever, especially in a malaria-risk area: seek care and testing immediately

[ ] Persistent vomiting or diarrhoea, blood in stool, or signs of dehydration

[ ] Breathing difficulty, chest pain, or severe headache

[ ] Any serious injury

In an emergency, call the local emergency number and contact your insurer's assistance line.

General good practice (not taken directly from the sources above)

[ ] Road safety: seat belts, helmets, avoid night driving where roads are unsafe

[ ] Water safety: check conditions, do not swim alone or after alcohol

[ ] After an animal bite or scratch: wash the wound thoroughly and seek urgent local advice

Editable source: checklists/02-in-transit-and-destination.md

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Post-travel checklist

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Medicines and prevention

[ ] Finish any course of malaria prophylaxis exactly as directed

[ ] Update your vaccination record

Symptoms: when to seek care

[ ] Fever after travel to a malaria-risk area, at any point in the following year: seek medical care and malaria testing the same day, even if you took prophylaxis

[ ] Persistent diarrhoea or vomiting

[ ] Jaundice (yellow skin or eyes)

[ ] Urinary problems

[ ] Skin problems or rash

[ ] Anogenital symptoms or possible sexually transmitted infection

[ ] Cough or other new respiratory symptoms

[ ] Worsening of a pre-existing condition

Seek review without waiting for a routine appointment if you were treated for malaria or another infection abroad, or if you may have been exposed to an infection (including an STI) even without symptoms.

What to tell the clinician

[ ] Countries and areas visited, and dates

[ ] Activities and exposures (food, water, insects, animals, freshwater, sexual contact)

[ ] Vaccinations and malaria prophylaxis taken

[ ] Any illness or treatment while abroad

Review

[ ] Replace used first-aid supplies

[ ] Keep notes for next time: insurer experience, local services, items you wished you had

Editable source: checklists/03-post-travel.md